# PLATFORM & SYSTEMS INTEGRATION REFERENCE

*dtdm.us Project Reference Document*

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19 categories · 150+ platforms mapped across payments, marketing, CRM, commerce, community, automation, and AI infrastructure.

## About This Document

This reference document maps the full ecosystem of platforms, tools, and systems that clients, prospects, and partners may be using — or that would be relevant to recommend when building digital products, marketing systems, automations, and sales infrastructure.

Use this file when:

- Scoping a new project to understand what tools to integrate with
- Evaluating what a client's existing stack implies about their sophistication
- Recommending the right tool for a specific function
- Writing sales copy or product pages that reference integrations
- Designing automation workflows and needing to know what connects to what

**TIER KEY** Free · Free/Paid · Paid · One-time · Enterprise · Usage *(per-transaction/use)*

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# Payment Processing

*How customers pay. Choice of processor affects fee structure, supported countries, payout speed, and checkout UX. Most platforms have a preferred processor — always verify compatibility before recommending.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Stripe** | Full-stack payments: cards, ACH, wallets, subscriptions, invoicing | SaaS, digital products, e-commerce, subscriptions | USAGE | *Industry default. Best docs. 2.9%+30¢ per transaction. Excellent for recurring billing.* |
| **PayU** | Payment gateway strong in Eastern Europe, India, Latin America | International businesses in emerging markets | USAGE | *Strong where Stripe is unavailable. Multiple local payment methods.* |
| **Braintree** | Payments subsidiary of PayPal — cards, PayPal, Venmo, wallets | Mid-market, marketplace, US-heavy | USAGE | *Owned by PayPal. Good for businesses needing PayPal+card in one SDK.* |
| **Checkout.com** | Enterprise payment processing with global acquiring | High-volume, enterprise, global expansion | PAID | *Lower rates at scale. Strong in UK/EU. Enterprise-first.* |
| **Square** | POS + online payments + invoicing | In-person retail, hybrid brick+digital | FREE/ PAID | *Great for physical locations. Ecosystem lock-in with hardware.* |
| **Authorize.net** | Legacy payment gateway, widely supported by banks | Established businesses, bank-preferred setups | PAID | *Older platform but trusted by banks and older enterprise clients.* |
| **GoCardless** | Bank-to-bank direct debit, recurring payments | SaaS, memberships, UK/EU businesses | USAGE | *Low fees for recurring. No card network dependency. Strong in EU.* |
| **Chargebee** | Subscription billing management and revenue ops | SaaS with complex billing logic | PAID | *Sits on top of Stripe/Braintree. Handles dunning, trials, upgrades.* |
| **Recurly** | Subscription management and billing platform | Mid-market SaaS, media, subscription boxes | PAID | *Competitor to Chargebee. Good churn recovery tools.* |
| **Zettle (PayPal)** | Mobile POS for in-person card acceptance | Pop-ups, markets, small retail | FREE/ PAID | *Hardware-based. Connects to PayPal ecosystem.* |
| **ThriveCart** | Checkout pages, upsells, affiliates, lifetime license | Digital product sellers, course creators | ONE-TIME | *$495–595 one-time. No monthly fee. Strong affiliate management.* |

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# Email & Marketing Automation

*The engine behind nurture sequences, broadcasts, and lifecycle marketing. Platform choice determines deliverability, automation depth, list segmentation, and tagging logic. Many digital product businesses run their entire backend on one of these.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Mailchimp** | Email marketing, basic automations, audience management | Small businesses, beginners, side projects | FREE/ PAID | *Most recognized brand. Clean interface but automation logic is limited vs. competitors.* |
| **ActiveCampaign** | Advanced email automation, CRM, lead scoring, site tracking | Serious digital marketers, course sellers, agencies | PAID | *Gold standard for automation depth. CRM built in. $29/mo starting.* |
| **Klaviyo** | Email + SMS, deep e-commerce data integration | E-commerce, Shopify brands, product businesses | FREE/ PAID | *Dominant in e-commerce email. Pulls product/order data natively.* |
| **ConvertKit** | Creator-focused email, simple automations, landing pages | Creators, newsletters, bloggers, solopreneurs | FREE/ PAID | *Clean UX. Strong subscriber tagging. Now called Kit.* |
| **MailerLite** | Email + automations + landing pages + forms | Small-medium businesses, cost-conscious operators | FREE/ PAID | *Free to 1k subscribers. Strong value. Good for TRACTION-type builds.* |
| **HubSpot Email** | Email within HubSpot CRM suite | B2B, sales-led companies, agencies | FREE/ PAID | *Most powerful when used with HubSpot CRM. Overkill if email-only.* |
| **Drip** | E-commerce email automation with behavioral triggers | E-commerce, D2C brands | PAID | *Similar to Klaviyo. Shopify/WooCommerce native.* |
| **Constant Contact** | Email marketing, event management, social tools | Nonprofits, local businesses, events | PAID | *Legacy platform. Strong event/RSVP tools. Not ideal for automation-heavy builds.* |
| **Beehiiv** | Newsletter platform with monetization features | Newsletter businesses, media, creator economy | FREE/ PAID | *Built by Morning Brew team. Paid subscriptions + ad network built in.* |
| **Substack** | Newsletter + paid subscription publishing | Writers, journalists, solo creators | FREE/ PAID | *Takes % of paid subscriptions. Built-in audience discovery.* |
| **Brevo (Sendinblue)** | Email, SMS, WhatsApp, transactional and marketing | European businesses, multi-channel needs | FREE/ PAID | *Strong transactional email. GDPR-friendly. Free plan is generous.* |

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# CRM & Lead Management

*Tracks contacts, deals, and pipelines. CRM selection signals the sales motion — high-volume outbound, inbound-led, or relationship-based. Many businesses use a CRM plus a separate email platform.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **HubSpot** | Full CRM suite — contacts, deals, sequences, reporting | Inbound-led B2B, agencies, growing teams | FREE/ PAID | *Free CRM is genuinely good. Expensive at scale. Most common in mid-market B2B.* |
| **Salesforce** | Enterprise CRM, deep customization, massive ecosystem | Enterprise, large sales teams, complex orgs | PAID | *Industry standard at enterprise level. Requires admin/implementation. High cost.* |
| **Pipedrive** | Visual pipeline CRM, deal-focused | SMB sales teams, deal-heavy sales motions | PAID | *Clean interface. Very visual. Strong for product/service sales pipelines.* |
| **Zoho CRM** | Full CRM with AI features, strong Zoho ecosystem integration | SMBs wanting all-in-one Zoho stack | FREE/ PAID | *Best value if already using Zoho products. Less intuitive than HubSpot.* |
| **Close CRM** | Built-in calling, email, SMS, pipeline management | Inside sales teams, high-activity outbound | PAID | *Communication-first CRM. Calling built in. Popular with outbound-heavy teams.* |
| **GoHighLevel** | CRM + funnels + email + SMS + calendar + pipeline | Agencies, local service businesses | PAID | *$97–297/mo. White-label ready. Replaces 6–8 tools. Agency favorite.* |
| **Gymsales** | Gym/fitness-specific CRM with lead management | Gyms, fitness studios | PAID | *Niche vertical CRM. Seen in gym platform integrations.* |
| **Gymleads** | Lead capture and follow-up CRM for fitness businesses | Gyms, personal trainers, fitness centers | PAID | *Simpler than Gymsales. Focused on lead conversion pipeline.* |
| **Referrizer** | Referral and loyalty automation for local businesses | Gyms, salons, local service businesses | PAID | *Automates referral asks and reward delivery. Common in fitness vertical.* |
| **Ripple** | Fitness-specific sales management system | Gyms, fitness studios | PAID | *Niche system seen in gym stack integrations.* |
| **Attio** | Modern relational CRM, data-flexible | Startups, VC-backed teams, modern B2B | FREE/ PAID | *Growing fast. Notion-like flexibility. Strong API.* |

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# Scheduling & Booking

*Appointment booking, class scheduling, and calendar management. Fitness and service businesses often use vertical-specific tools (Mindbody, Glofox) over generic options. Instagram “Book Now” connects to ~46 of these platforms.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Mindbody** | Class scheduling, memberships, POS for wellness/fitness | Gyms, yoga studios, wellness centers | PAID | *Dominant in fitness vertical. Expensive but deeply integrated in the space.* |
| **Acuity Scheduling** | Appointment booking, intake forms, payment collection | Solo practitioners, coaches, consultants | PAID | *Owned by Squarespace. Clean UX. Strong for 1-on-1 booking.* |
| **Vagaro** | Booking, POS, memberships for beauty/fitness/wellness | Salons, spas, fitness studios | PAID | *Common in beauty vertical. Lower cost than Mindbody.* |
| **Glofox** | Gym/studio management — booking, billing, reporting | Boutique fitness studios, CrossFit boxes | PAID | *Fitness-specific. Strong mobile app for members.* |
| **Calendly** | Simple appointment scheduling, calendar sync | Sales calls, consulting, interviews | FREE/ PAID | *Most recognized scheduling tool. Simple but limited for complex scenarios.* |
| **Cal.com** | Open-source scheduling, highly customizable | Developers, privacy-conscious businesses | FREE/ PAID | *Calendly alternative. Self-hostable. Growing fast.* |
| **Setmore** | Appointment booking with team and class features | Small service businesses | FREE/ PAID | *Free tier is generous. Connects to Instagram Book Now.* |
| **SimplyBook.me** | Feature-rich booking for service businesses | Complex service businesses, international | FREE/ PAID | *Highly customizable. Strong feature set for price. Common in spa/salon.* |
| **Booksy** | Marketplace + booking for beauty/barber professionals | Barbers, hairdressers, beauty professionals | PAID | *Has built-in marketplace discovery. Popular in beauty vertical.* |
| **GlossGenius** | All-in-one for beauty and wellness professionals | Independent beauty professionals | PAID | *Clean design focus. Cards, booking, client management.* |
| **ABC Fitness** | Club management software for larger fitness operations | Multi-location gyms, health clubs | PAID | *Enterprise-leaning. Billing, access control, reporting.* |
| **Zen Planner** | Gym/martial arts studio management | CrossFit, martial arts, functional fitness | PAID | *Strong in boutique gym and martial arts segment.* |
| **ClubReady** | Franchise gym management software | Franchise fitness brands | PAID | *Built for franchise operations with multi-location controls.* |

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# Fitness, Wellness & Health Apps

*Wearables, tracking apps, and wellness platforms. Relevant for integration when building health-adjacent products, apps, or services that benefit from user health data or workout history.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Wellhub (Gympass)** | Corporate wellness benefit connecting employees to gyms/apps | Gyms seeking corporate clients | PAID | *Formerly Gympass. Major source of gym memberships via employer benefit.* |
| **ClassPass** | Fitness class marketplace/subscription | Boutique studios wanting discovery + new members | PAID | *Drives studio discovery and fills off-peak slots.* |
| **Apple Health** | Central health data store on iOS | Any fitness/health app on iPhone | FREE | *HealthKit API. Permission-based data access. Highly trusted by users.* |
| **Google Fit** | Android health data platform | Android fitness apps | FREE | *Less dominant than Apple Health. Activity and vitals data.* |
| **MyFitnessPal** | Nutrition tracking and calorie counting | Nutrition-adjacent apps and services | FREE/ PAID | *Largest nutrition database. API available. Common in diet/coaching apps.* |
| **Strava** | Activity tracking for running, cycling, endurance sports | Running/cycling communities and coaching apps | FREE/ PAID | *Social layer for athletes. Strong API for activity data.* |
| **Whoop** | Recovery and strain tracking wearable | Performance-focused athletes, high-performers | PAID | *Subscription hardware model. Data-rich API. High engagement users.* |
| **Garmin Connect** | Fitness data from Garmin wearables | Endurance athletes, outdoors, military | FREE | *Deep sensor data. API for developers. Strong in running/triathlon.* |
| **Fitbit / Google** | Consumer fitness tracking wearables | General fitness consumers | FREE/ PAID | *Now under Google. Large installed base. API access available.* |
| **Oura Ring** | Sleep and recovery tracking ring | Sleep-focused, biohackers, executives | PAID | *Subscription hardware. Sleep data is best-in-class. Growing fast.* |

SECTION 06 / 19

# Analytics & Reporting

*Turning data into decisions. Analytics stack choice depends on whether the need is website behavior, product usage, business intelligence, or all three. Most businesses underinvest here until they need it urgently.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Google Analytics 4** | Website and app behavior analytics | Any web property | FREE | *Industry standard. Replaced Universal Analytics. Event-based model.* |
| **Looker (Google)** | Business intelligence and data visualization | Data teams, enterprise BI | PAID | *Seen in gym platform stack. Google-owned. SQL-based data exploration.* |
| **Tableau** | Data visualization and BI dashboards | Enterprise analytics, data-heavy orgs | PAID | *Industry leader in data viz. Salesforce-owned. High cost but powerful.* |
| **Mixpanel** | Product analytics — user behavior, funnels, retention | SaaS, apps, product teams | FREE/ PAID | *Best-in-class for product analytics. Event-based, user-level tracking.* |
| **Heap** | Auto-capture product analytics | Product teams wanting retroactive analysis | FREE/ PAID | *Captures everything by default. No pre-instrumentation needed.* |
| **Amplitude** | Product analytics, behavioral cohorts, journey analysis | Growth teams, product-led companies | FREE/ PAID | *Competitor to Mixpanel. Strong behavioral analytics.* |
| **Hotjar** | Heatmaps, session recordings, user feedback | UX, CRO, landing page optimization | FREE/ PAID | *Visual analytics. See where users click and drop off.* |
| **Microsoft Clarity** | Free heatmaps and session recordings | Any web property | FREE | *Hotjar alternative from Microsoft. Completely free. Good for small teams.* |
| **Datadog** | Infrastructure and application performance monitoring | DevOps, engineering teams | PAID | *Technical monitoring. Logs, metrics, traces. Not user-facing analytics.* |
| **PostHog** | Open-source product analytics + feature flags | Developer-led product teams, privacy-focused | FREE/ PAID | *Self-hostable. Combines analytics, session replay, feature flags.* |
| **Metabase** | Open-source BI tool, SQL + no-code queries | Small data teams, startups | FREE/ PAID | *Good entry-level BI. Connects to most databases.* |

SECTION 07 / 19

# Social Media & Advertising

*Ad pixels, tracking, and social platforms. Understanding which pixels a client runs tells you a lot about their acquisition strategy. Every business running paid traffic has at least one of these installed.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Facebook / Meta Pixel** | Conversion tracking and audience building for Meta ads | Any business running Facebook/Instagram ads | FREE | *Most installed pixel on the web. Required for Meta ad optimization.* |
| **Google Ads / GTM** | Search, display, YouTube ad tracking and tag management | Any business running Google ads | FREE | *Google Tag Manager manages all pixel deployments. Required for Google Ads.* |
| **TikTok Pixel** | Conversion tracking for TikTok ads | Consumer brands, younger demographics | FREE | *Growing fast. Required for TikTok ad optimization. Events API also available.* |
| **Pinterest Tag** | Conversion tracking for Pinterest ads | Visual products, home, fashion, DIY | FREE | *Niche but strong ROI for visual product categories.* |
| **Snapchat Pixel** | Conversion tracking for Snapchat ads | Under-35 consumer audiences | FREE | *Smaller reach but less saturated. Worth testing for the right audience.* |
| **LinkedIn Insight Tag** | Conversion tracking and audience building for LinkedIn ads | B2B, professional services, enterprise | FREE | *Required for LinkedIn ad optimization. Expensive CPCs but high intent B2B.* |
| **Twitter/X Pixel** | Conversion tracking for X/Twitter ads | Tech, media, commentary, cultural brands | FREE | *Declining ad effectiveness but still relevant for tech/media audiences.* |
| **Loud Rumor** | Gym/fitness marketing agency with proprietary tools | Fitness studios and gyms running paid ads | PAID | *Agency model. Seen in gym integration stacks. Focus on lead gen for fitness.* |
| **Loyalsnap** | Automated marketing for fitness studios | Fitness studios, boutique gyms | PAID | *Fitness-specific automated marketing. Works with Mindbody data.* |
| **Referrizer** | Referral automation and reputation management | Local service businesses | PAID | *Automates referral requests and Google review asks.* |

SECTION 08 / 19

# E-commerce & Storefronts

*Where digital and physical products are sold. Platform choice determines checkout UX, affiliate capability, and integration complexity. Digital product sellers often use simpler tools than physical product sellers.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Shopify** | E-commerce platform for physical and digital products | Physical product brands, D2C | PAID | *Dominant e-commerce platform. Massive app ecosystem. $39+/mo.* |
| **Gumroad** | Simple digital product storefront | Creators, solopreneurs, first digital product | FREE/ PAID | *Zero monthly fee option. Takes % of sales. Best for simple digital products.* |
| **Whop** | Digital products, communities, software access | Discord communities, tools, info products | FREE/ PAID | *Growing fast. Strong for community + digital product bundles.* |
| **Stan Store** | Link-in-bio storefront for creators | Social media creators, coaches | PAID | *$29/mo. Replaces Linktree + Gumroad. Popular on TikTok/Instagram.* |
| **Lemon Squeezy** | Digital products + software licensing + subscriptions | Software developers, SaaS builders | PAID | *Handles EU VAT automatically. Built for software/SaaS digital delivery.* |
| **ThriveCart** | Checkout, upsells, affiliates, LTV maximization | Digital product sellers, course creators | ONE-TIME | *One-time license. Strong upsell/bump mechanics. Affiliate management built in.* |
| **WooCommerce** | WordPress e-commerce plugin | WordPress sites, flexible/customized stores | FREE/ PAID | *Free plugin, paid for hosting/extensions. Full control but requires maintenance.* |
| **Etsy** | Marketplace for handmade, vintage, digital downloads | Craft sellers, digital download creators | USAGE | *Built-in audience. Good for templates, printables, digital art.* |
| **Payhip** | Digital product and course sales | Creators wanting simple no-monthly-fee option | FREE/ PAID | *Generous free tier. Handles EU VAT. Simple alternative to Gumroad.* |

SECTION 09 / 19

# Course & Community Platforms

*Where knowledge products live. Platform choice affects course UX, community engagement, payment integration, and affiliate capability. Many creators run separate tools for course delivery and community.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Kajabi** | All-in-one courses, communities, email, funnels, podcasting | Serious course creators, knowledge businesses | PAID | *$149+/mo. Premium positioning. Replaces many tools. Strong brand.* |
| **Teachable** | Course platform with payment and affiliate tools | Course creators, educators | FREE/ PAID | *Popular mid-market option. Less feature-rich than Kajabi but lower cost.* |
| **Thinkific** | Course platform with community and commerce | Course creators, corporate training | FREE/ PAID | *Kajabi/Teachable competitor. Good free tier. White-label option.* |
| **Skool** | Community + courses in a single interface | Community-led businesses, coaching programs | PAID | *$99/mo flat. Alex Hormozi-backed. Growing fast. Gamification built in.* |
| **Circle** | Community platform with events and courses | Premium communities, cohort-based courses | PAID | *Notion-like modern community UX. Strong for async + live hybrid.* |
| **Podia** | Courses, digital downloads, communities, email | Small creators wanting simple all-in-one | PAID | *Simpler than Kajabi. Good value at lower tier.* |
| **Maven** | Cohort-based course platform | Live/cohort courses, expert educators | USAGE | *Revenue share model. Built for live teaching formats.* |
| **Mighty Networks** | Community + courses + native app | Communities wanting a branded app | PAID | *Has native app builder. Strong community-first model.* |

SECTION 10 / 19

# Funnel & Landing Page Builders

*Where prospects convert. Funnel builders determine the structure of the buying journey. Choice depends on technical comfort, budget, and integration needs.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **ClickFunnels 2.0** | Funnel builder, courses, CRM, email, affiliate center | Info product sellers, coaching, digital products | PAID | *$147+/mo. Russell Brunson brand. Large community. Mature ecosystem.* |
| **Systeme.io** | All-in-one funnels, email, courses, affiliates | Budget-conscious marketers, beginners | FREE/ PAID | *Free plan is strong. $27/mo for full suite. Strong value at entry level.* |
| **GoHighLevel** | Agency-grade funnels, CRM, automation, white-label | Marketing agencies, local service businesses | PAID | *$97–297/mo. White-label for resale. Most feature-dense option available.* |
| **Leadpages** | Landing pages and opt-in forms | Marketers needing fast standalone landing pages | PAID | *Solid drag-and-drop. Not a full funnel builder. Good for lead capture.* |
| **Unbounce** | Conversion-focused landing pages with AI assist | CRO-focused teams, agencies | PAID | *Smart Traffic feature auto-routes to best variant. Strong for paid traffic.* |
| **Webflow** | Visual web design + CMS + hosting | Designers, no-code builders, marketing sites | FREE/ PAID | *Not a funnel builder but often used for landing pages. Full design control.* |
| **Carrd** | Simple one-page sites | Solo creators, link-in-bio, simple landing pages | FREE/ PAID | *$9/yr Pro plan. Extremely lightweight. Good for fast single-page builds.* |

SECTION 11 / 19

# Accounting & Finance

*Business financial operations. Most small-medium businesses use one of the top three. Freelancers and solo operators often start with Wave. Integration matters for automated invoice creation from CRM/e-commerce data.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **QuickBooks** | Accounting, invoicing, payroll, tax prep | US-based SMBs, established businesses | PAID | *Most used small business accounting software in the US. $30+/mo.* |
| **Xero** | Cloud accounting, invoicing, bank reconciliation | SMBs, UK/ANZ preference, modern stack | PAID | *Strong QuickBooks competitor. Better API. Preferred by modern accountants.* |
| **FreshBooks** | Invoicing, time tracking, expenses for service businesses | Freelancers, service businesses | PAID | *Simpler than QB/Xero. Great for service-based billing.* |
| **Wave** | Free accounting, invoicing, receipt scanning | Freelancers, very small businesses | FREE/ PAID | *Free accounting core. Charges for payroll and payment processing.* |
| **Pilot** | Outsourced bookkeeping + accounting service | Startups, funded companies | PAID | *Managed service, not software. Uses Xero/QBO as backend. VC-popular.* |
| **Stripe Revenue Recognition** | Automated revenue recognition for subscription businesses | SaaS with complex billing | PAID | *Add-on to Stripe. GAAP-compliant revenue reporting for subscriptions.* |

SECTION 12 / 19

# Staff, Operations & HR

*Team management, scheduling, and HR tools. Fitness businesses commonly use workforce scheduling tools. Agencies and distributed teams lean toward async communication stacks.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Deputy** | Shift scheduling, time tracking, workforce management | Shift-based businesses, gyms, retail, hospitality | PAID | *Common in gym/fitness vertical for staff scheduling.* |
| **When I Work** | Employee scheduling and time clocking | SMB shift-based teams | PAID | *Deputy competitor. Clean UX. Strong in retail and fitness.* |
| **Gusto** | Payroll, benefits, HR compliance | US SMBs with employees | PAID | *Most popular SMB payroll platform. Handles W-2s, benefits, onboarding.* |
| **BambooHR** | HR software — onboarding, performance, PTO, org chart | SMBs with growing people ops needs | PAID | *Mid-market HR platform. Strong onboarding and org management.* |
| **Rippling** | HR, IT, payroll unified platform | Tech-forward SMBs and mid-market | PAID | *Fastest-growing HR platform. Handles HR+IT in one. Strong automation.* |
| **Slack** | Team messaging and channel-based communication | Tech companies, remote teams, agencies | FREE/ PAID | *Default team communication for most digital businesses.* |
| **Notion** | Docs, wikis, databases, project management | Knowledge workers, startups, product teams | FREE/ PAID | *Internal knowledge base and project management hybrid.* |
| **Asana** | Project and task management | Marketing teams, agencies, project-heavy orgs | FREE/ PAID | *Strong project tracking. Good for campaign and deliverable management.* |
| **Linear** | Issue tracking and project management for software teams | Engineering teams, product development | FREE/ PAID | *Modern Jira alternative. Fast, clean, developer-preferred.* |

SECTION 13 / 19

# Automation & Integration Middleware

*The glue between systems. Every business that uses more than 3–4 tools eventually needs middleware. Knowing this stack tells you how automated a client's operations already are.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Zapier** | No-code workflow automation between apps | Non-technical teams, simple automation needs | FREE/ PAID | *Most recognized. 6,000+ integrations. Expensive at high volume.* |
| **Make (Integromat)** | Visual workflow automation with complex logic | Power users, agencies, complex workflows | FREE/ PAID | *More powerful and cheaper than Zapier. Visual canvas. Webhook native.* |
| **n8n** | Open-source workflow automation | Technical teams, privacy-focused, self-hosted | FREE/ PAID | *Self-hostable. Growing fast. Best for developers.* |
| **Pabbly Connect** | Zapier alternative, one-time pricing available | Budget-conscious automators | ONE-TIME | *Lifetime license available. Good value for stable workflows.* |
| **Pipedream** | Developer-focused event-driven automation | Developers building complex integrations | FREE/ PAID | *Code-first. Node.js/Python support. Strong for custom API work.* |
| **Workato** | Enterprise integration platform (iPaaS) | Enterprise IT, complex B2B integrations | PAID | *Enterprise-grade. Expensive. Replaces MuleSoft in some use cases.* |
| **Tray.io** | Enterprise automation and integration | Mid-enterprise, technical marketing ops | PAID | *More flexible than Workato for custom logic. Strong API connector.* |

SECTION 14 / 19

# Customer Support & Communication

*How businesses talk to customers. Support stack choice affects response time, ticket organization, and knowledge base management. Live chat also drives conversion for high-ticket products.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Intercom** | Live chat, help desk, AI support, product tours | SaaS, apps, digital product businesses | PAID | *Premium positioning. Strong for in-app messaging and onboarding flows.* |
| **Zendesk** | Enterprise ticketing, help desk, knowledge base | Mid-enterprise, high-volume support | PAID | *Industry standard for complex support operations. Expensive.* |
| **Freshdesk** | Help desk ticketing and live chat | SMBs wanting structured support | FREE/ PAID | *Strong free tier. Good Zendesk alternative at lower cost.* |
| **Crisp** | Live chat, shared inbox, chatbot | Startups, small teams | FREE/ PAID | *Good free tier. Multi-channel inbox. Strong WhatsApp integration.* |
| **Tidio** | Live chat + AI chatbot for e-commerce | E-commerce, Shopify stores | FREE/ PAID | *Strong Shopify integration. AI chatbot on free tier.* |
| **Gorgias** | Helpdesk built for e-commerce, Shopify-native | Shopify brands, e-commerce | PAID | *Pulls order data into tickets automatically. E-commerce first.* |
| **Front** | Shared inbox for teams — email, chat, SMS, social | Customer-facing teams, agencies | PAID | *Turns email into a collaborative team inbox. Good for shared accounts.* |

SECTION 15 / 19

# SMS & Messaging

*Direct mobile communication. SMS has 98% open rates. Businesses using SMS for marketing or support see significantly higher engagement than email alone.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Twilio** | Programmable SMS, voice, email, WhatsApp API | Developers, custom communication workflows | USAGE | *Infrastructure layer. Used by most SMS apps as their backend.* |
| **Attentive** | SMS marketing platform for e-commerce | E-commerce, D2C brands | PAID | *Enterprise SMS marketing. Strong compliance tools. E-commerce focused.* |
| **Klaviyo SMS** | SMS + email in one platform | E-commerce brands already on Klaviyo | PAID | *Unified with email flows. Reduces vendor count for e-commerce stacks.* |
| **SimpleTexting** | SMS marketing campaigns and two-way messaging | Small-medium businesses | PAID | *Simple bulk SMS with keyword triggers. Good for local businesses.* |
| **SlickText** | SMS marketing and loyalty for small businesses | Restaurants, retail, local service businesses | PAID | *Loyalty/rewards SMS programs. Lower-cost option.* |
| **EZTexting** | SMS marketing for SMBs | Small businesses new to SMS marketing | PAID | *Easy onboarding. Templates library. Good starting point.* |

SECTION 16 / 19

# Access Control & Physical Security

*Relevant for any business with a physical location — gyms, co-working spaces, studios. Modern access control systems integrate with membership software.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Kisi** | Cloud-based door access control | Offices, co-working spaces, gyms | PAID | *Integrates with Google Workspace, Slack, Mindbody. API-first.* |
| **Brivo** | Cloud access control and video surveillance | Commercial buildings, gyms, multi-tenant | PAID | *Strong in gym vertical. Membership-triggered access.* |
| **Salto** | Smart lock and access management systems | Hotels, offices, residential | PAID | *Hardware + cloud. Strong in hospitality and commercial.* |
| **Dormakaba** | Physical access control hardware and software | Enterprise buildings, hospitality | PAID | *Established hardware vendor. Used in large facilities.* |
| **OpenPath** | Mobile-first access control | Modern offices, tech companies | PAID | *Tap-to-unlock via phone. Acquired by Motorola Solutions.* |

SECTION 17 / 19

# Video, Webinar & Live Events

*Video infrastructure for marketing, sales calls, webinars, and live events. Every business running a sales process or online education needs at least one of these.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Zoom** | Video calls, webinars, virtual events | Universal — calls, demos, webinars | FREE/ PAID | *Default video tool for most businesses. Webinar add-on available.* |
| **Google Meet** | Video calls integrated with Google Workspace | Google Workspace users | FREE/ PAID | *Free with Google account. Simple but limited features vs Zoom.* |
| **Loom** | Async video messaging and screen recording | Remote teams, sales, documentation | FREE/ PAID | *Strong for async communication. Screen + cam recording. Sales use case growing.* |
| **StreamYard** | Browser-based live streaming to multiple platforms | Livestreamers, podcasters, media companies | FREE/ PAID | *Multi-destination streaming. Good for LinkedIn + YouTube + Facebook simultaneously.* |
| **Vimeo** | Professional video hosting and sharing | Marketing teams, agencies, creatives | FREE/ PAID | *Ad-free video hosting. Password protection. Strong for client deliveries.* |
| **Wistia** | Video hosting with marketing analytics | B2B marketing, product demos, video SEO | FREE/ PAID | *Viewer-level analytics. CTA overlays. Email gate on videos.* |
| **Riverside.fm** | High-quality podcast and video recording | Podcasters, interview-format content | FREE/ PAID | *Records local tracks for each participant. Studio-quality remote recording.* |
| **Demio** | Webinar platform built for marketing | Marketers running automated or live webinars | PAID | *Cleaner UX than Zoom webinars. Good automation/replay features.* |

SECTION 18 / 19

# Website, CMS & Hosting

*The digital home. Platform choice sets the ceiling on design flexibility, SEO performance, and long-term maintenance overhead.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **WordPress** | Open-source CMS, complete content and e-commerce control | Content-heavy sites, SEO-focused, custom builds | FREE/ PAID | *Powers ~43% of the web. Huge plugin ecosystem. WooCommerce for e-commerce.* |
| **Webflow** | Visual design-first CMS and hosting | Designers, agencies, marketing sites | FREE/ PAID | *Best design control without code. Strong CMS. Growing fast.* |
| **Squarespace** | All-in-one website builder and hosting | Service businesses, portfolios, small brands | PAID | *Beautiful templates. Less flexible than Webflow. Owns Acuity.* |
| **Wix** | Drag-and-drop website builder | Small businesses, beginners | FREE/ PAID | *Most flexible visual builder. SEO has improved significantly.* |
| **Framer** | Design-to-publish website platform | Startups, SaaS, modern marketing sites | FREE/ PAID | *Growing fast. Strong design system support. AI features.* |
| **Ghost** | Publishing platform for newsletters and blogs | Writers, newsletter businesses, media | FREE/ PAID | *Substack alternative with full ownership. Membership + email built in.* |
| **Vercel** | Frontend cloud deployment platform | Developers deploying Next.js/React apps | FREE/ PAID | *Instant deploys. Edge functions. The default for modern web apps.* |
| **Cloudflare Pages** | Static site hosting with edge computing | Developers, JAMstack sites | FREE/ PAID | *Free tier is excellent. Integrated with Cloudflare security and CDN.* |

SECTION 19 / 19

# AI & Emerging Tools

*The fastest-moving category. AI tools are increasingly embedded into every other category. Knowing which AI tools a business uses signals their technical sophistication and workflow automation maturity.*

| TOOL / PLATFORM | WHAT IT DOES | BEST FOR | TIER | NOTES & CONTEXT |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **OpenAI / ChatGPT** | LLM API + consumer AI assistant | Developers, knowledge workers, content creators | FREE/ PAID | *Most recognized AI brand. GPT-4o is current flagship. Strong ecosystem.* |
| **Anthropic / Claude** | LLM API + consumer AI assistant | Developers, safety-focused use cases, long context | FREE/ PAID | *Strong reasoning, long context, nuanced instruction following.* |
| **Midjourney** | AI image generation (Discord + web) | Designers, marketers, content creators | PAID | *Best-in-class image quality for creative work. No free tier.* |
| **ElevenLabs** | AI voice synthesis and cloning | Podcasters, video creators, accessibility | FREE/ PAID | *Most realistic AI voice. Voice cloning from short sample.* |
| **Runway** | AI video generation and editing | Video creators, studios, marketers | FREE/ PAID | *Leading AI video tool. Gen-3 model is state-of-the-art.* |
| **Descript** | AI-powered audio/video editing via transcript | Podcasters, video creators, marketers | FREE/ PAID | *Edit video by editing text transcript. Overdub voice cloning.* |
| **Perplexity** | AI-powered search and research | Research, quick fact-finding, competitive intel | FREE/ PAID | *Real-time web search + AI synthesis. Growing fast.* |
| **Cursor** | AI-first code editor | Developers building with AI assistance | FREE/ PAID | *Fork of VS Code with deep AI integration. Dominant in AI-assisted dev.* |
| **Make (AI)** | Visual automation with AI model nodes | Automation builders, AI workflow development | FREE/ PAID | *Native AI steps in workflows. LLM + image gen + function nodes.* |
| **Magica** | Node-based AI workflow platform | AI workflow developers, content automation | PAID | *Build, run, and automate AI pipelines. Workflows, direct model runs, webhooks. API-first. (Formerly Galaxy AI.)* |

*Update this reference as new tools are encountered or client stacks evolve.*